PUBLIC TRANSLATION ARTIFACT · 01 IN READING ORDER

PATREON

/ APPLE IAP

PLAIN-LANGUAGE COMPANION

For leadership, creators, fans, product teams, and policy teams.

> *"The moment a fan taps 'Join' inside the iOS app, the relationship-coded act of support becomes a transaction-coded purchase on Apple's terms. That is the break."*

ARTIFACT FAMILY

#	ARTIFACT	ACCESS
01	**Translation Artifact**	***← This document***
02	Diagnostic Artifact	**Public**
03	Redesign Executive Summary	**Public**
04	Redesign Artifact — Path A	**Restricted**
05	Redesign Artifact — Path B	**Restricted**

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CLASSIFICATION Public · 01 in reading order · start here

ARTIFACT FAMILY

#	ARTIFACT	ROLE	ACCESS
01	**Translation Artifact**	Plain-language companion	**Public · this document**
02	Diagnostic Artifact	Full structural proof	Public
03	Redesign Executive Summary	Board summary, both paths	Public
04	Redesign Artifact · Path A	Restricted builder spec	**Restricted**
05	Redesign Artifact · Path B	Restricted builder spec	**Restricted**

READING ORDER

ROUTE	DESCRIPTION
Reader route (start here)	This document is the plain-language entry point. Read it first · before the Diagnostic or Redesign Artifacts.
Formal review route	Diagnostic Artifact · Redesign Executive Summary · Translation Artifact · Restricted Redesign Artifact A or B. The Diagnostic is the epistemic foundation. This document does not precede it.

JUDGMENT BOUNDARY

This artifact is based entirely on publicly available evidence. It makes no claim about intentional deception, bad faith, or misconduct by Patreon or Apple. The structural diagnosis is derived from convergent public evidence, not from internal systems or confidential communications. It does not introduce independent evidentiary claims.

SECTION QUICK REFERENCE

AT A GLANCE

Eleven items. Start with The problem and The break · everything else follows from there.

ITEM	PLAIN-LANGUAGE SUMMARY
The problem	Patreon's creator-fan patronage model cannot be faithfully expressed inside Apple's subscription-only payment grammar.
The break	When a fan taps "Join" on iOS, creator-defined support becomes an Apple-governed subscription transaction.
What fails	Payment, refund, remittance, creator output, and fan intent no longer remain inside one coherent relationship.

Hidden burden	Creators explain workarounds, fans navigate confusion, Patreon support performs manual migration, and off-platform instructions become load-bearing.
Plain analogy — Path A	Like a translator at the border: Apple receives a subscription-shaped object it can process; Patreon keeps the original patronage relationship intact behind it, on the creator's terms.
Plain analogy — Path B	Like a membership club with booths inside: you pay one fee at the door (Patreon), then choose which creators to support inside Patreon's system. Apple sees the door payment, not the creator-level choices inside.
Path A — The Decoupler	Preserve Patreon's bilateral creator-fan model by putting Apple behind a translation layer. The continuity-preserving path.
Path B — The Allocation Shift	Replace bilateral creator-fan payment with platform-level funding and internal allocation. Valid but category-transforming.
Proof	Same pressure → different response. Apple policy changes no longer automatically become creator chaos, fan confusion, or manual migration load.
Biggest risk	Treating the two exits as feature options. They are mutually exclusive structural futures.
Decision rule	Choose Path A or Path B before build begins. Do not pursue both simultaneously. Attempting both recreates the structural collapse both paths exist to exit.

SECTION GLOSSARY

PLAIN-LANGUAGE TERMS

Key terms used throughout this artifact family, each given its plain-language meaning.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Primitive Switch	The moment Patreon's creator-fan support relationship is forced into Apple's subscription payment system. The break point.
Host-Constrained Primitive Mismatch	A failure where a platform's core economic model cannot be expressed inside the host system it depends on. Patreon's founding patronage model cannot be expressed inside Apple's IAP grammar.
Payment grammar	Apple's IAP grammar recognises standardised purchase and subscription forms. It does not natively express "pay this creator when they publish, up to my chosen cap."
Ghost structure	Hidden human work compensating for missing architecture: creator explanations, Discord instructions, manual migration support, off-platform workarounds.
Credit Event Log	Path A's truth object. The internal record that preserves fan credits, creator publication events, debits, refunds, and reconciliation. The primary record that governs entitlement and payout.
Patronage Allocation Ledger	Path B's truth object. The internal record that tracks fan balances, allocation rules, creator payouts, and allocation events. The primary record of all creator income.
Recapture	The old failure returning inside the new system, usually through metrics, custody, incentives, or interface language.

Vanish List	The non-negotiable list of behaviours that must stop before redesign can hold.
Category collapse (Path B)	The failure where the allocation interface starts to feel like a generic financial tool rather than a direct creator-fan support relationship. The creator no longer feels “these fans support my work.”
Payor of record (Path B)	Under Path B, Patreon pays creators — not individual fans. This changes tax documents, accounting, and creator-facing financial records.
Translation layer (Path A)	The architectural layer that holds Patreon’s internal patronage object while presenting Apple with a compatible subscription event. The price of preserving Patreon’s bilateral identity.

SECTION 0

WHAT THIS DOCUMENT IS

This Translation Artifact explains Patreon’s structural diagnosis and the two replacement paths in clear, plain language. It is not a legal complaint, a policy argument, a product roadmap, or a public-relations document. It does not introduce new evidence. It translates the existing Diagnostic and Redesign Artifacts so the structural issue can be understood before entering the full specifications.

What this document does not say:

→ It does not say Patreon acted in bad faith

→ It does not say Apple acted illegally

→ It does not say the 30% fee is the root problem

→ It does not say web checkout is useless

→ It does not say Path B is the recommended path for most organisations

→ It does not say Path B is a minor product option

→ It does not say both paths can be pursued together

→ It does not claim access to Patreon’s internal systems, contracts, or unpublished data

What it does say: Patreon’s founding patronage model cannot be faithfully executed at the iOS payment boundary because Apple’s payment system recognises a different economic object. Two structurally valid exits exist. They require a leadership identity decision, not a product or engineering decision.

SECTION 1

THE SYSTEM IN ONE SENTENCE

Before any comparison or diagnosis: the governing condition in one sentence. Everything that follows is a consequence of this.

GOVERNING DIAGNOSIS

Patreon is not facing a billing migration problem. Patreon is being forced to translate creator-defined patronage into Apple’s subscription grammar — and that translation changes what Patreon is.

SECTION 2

WHAT PATREON SAYS VS WHAT APPLE'S SYSTEM DOES

The core mismatch across four dimensions. Each row shows what Patreon's model requires and what Apple's payment system delivers. The gap between the two columns is not a technical problem · it is a structural one. Two different economic objects are trying to share one payment event.

Patreon's model is relationship-coded. A fan supports a creator. The creator defines the terms. In the strongest original form, the fan pays when the creator publishes, up to a chosen limit. Apple's in-app purchase model is transaction-coded. A user buys a standard subscription. Apple controls payment initiation, refund authority, and remittance timing.

PATREON'S PATRONAGE MODEL	APPLE'S PAYMENT GRAMMAR
Fan supports a specific creator	User buys a subscription product
Creator defines support terms	Apple recognises standardised billing forms
Payment can follow creative output	Payment follows a calendar cycle
Fan intent and creator output are linked	Payment event and creative act are separated
Patreon holds the relationship	Apple governs the iOS payment event

This is not a communication gap. It is a structural mismatch between two different economic systems.

SECTION 2.1

A CONCRETE EXAMPLE: THE IRREGULAR PUBLISHER

A creator posts irregularly: four posts one month, nothing the next, two the month after. In Patreon's original per-creation logic, the fan pays when work appears. The fan might pay £40 in a busy month and nothing in a quiet one. That is the relationship both parties understood.

In Apple's subscription grammar, payment wants a fixed calendar rhythm. The fan is pushed toward a monthly subscription that charges the same regardless of whether the creator published. The billing event and the creative act separate. The creator must now choose: bill fans for months with no content, or change their economics entirely. Neither option was part of the original relationship.

That is where the relationship starts to deform. Not because anyone decided to change it. Because the boundary forced a translation, and the translation changed the object.

EVIDENCE NOTE

The downstream consequences described throughout this document are structural inferences derived from Patreon's own public communications, Apple's developer documentation, and the diagnostic's evidence base. They are not claims about unpublished systems or internal intent.

SECTION 3

THE PRIMITIVE SWITCH

One moment. One action. One irrecoverable translation. Everything in this document traces back to the row marked iOS Payment Initiation.

The first structural break happens at one moment:

The fan taps “Join” inside the iOS app.

Before that moment, the fan’s act is relationship-coded: “I want to support this creator on these terms.”

After that moment, the act must become transaction-coded: “I am buying an Apple-compatible subscription.”

> CORE MOMENT
>
> ***That is the Primitive Switch.***

At that point:

→ Apple controls the payment event
→ Apple controls refund authority
→ Apple controls remittance timing
→ Patreon’s per-creation logic is no longer native to the transaction
→ The creator’s chosen economic grammar is compressed into Apple’s recognised billing form

Everything else is downstream. Every visible problem — the fee, the multiplier confusion, the refund paradox, the web checkout workarounds, the policy reversals — can be traced back to this moment.

SECTION 4

WHY THE VISIBLE PROBLEMS KEEP RETURNING

The visible problems are not separate failures. They are debris from the Primitive Switch.

VISIBLE PROBLEM	STRUCTURAL SOURCE
30% Apple fee	Payment must pass through Apple’s system.
Multiplier confusion	Per-creation support is compressed into a monthly subscription equivalent.
Refund paradox	Apple controls refund decisions while creators carry delivery expectations.
Remittance delay	Payment timing follows Apple’s settlement logic, not Patreon’s patronage logic.
Web checkout workarounds	The app cannot express the desired support relationship directly.
Creator confusion	Creators must explain a structural translation they did not design.
Repeated policy reversals	Patreon remains dependent on a host grammar it does not control.

The same failure keeps returning because the core relationship is still being forced through the wrong payment grammar.

SECTION 5

WHERE THE BURDEN LANDS

STRUCTURAL PRINCIPLE

When architecture cannot carry a function, people carry it. That hidden labour is the ghost structure.

This table names who absorbs each piece of the failure and how.

BURDEN CARRIER	WHAT THEY CURRENTLY CARRY
Creators	Explain iOS price differences, tell fans to use the web, absorb trust damage, translate policy changes to communities.
Fans	Work out where to join, why prices differ, why support no longer behaves as expected.
Patreon support and product teams	Handle manual migration, rebuild tooling after Apple changes, respond to Apple policy reversals, manage creator uncertainty.
Off-platform communities	Discord posts, Twitter threads, community guides, and creator instructions become informal infrastructure.

These are not healthy community behaviours. They are compensatory structures. The redesign succeeds only when this burden moves from people into the architecture.

SECTION 6

WHY PREVIOUS FIXES HAVE NOT WORKED

Five interventions that acted inside the problem rather than on it. Each one addressed a symptom without touching the Primitive Switch. The final column states why each one fails by design, not by execution. The pattern is the same across all five: the frame was wrong, so the fix reproduced the failure in a new form.

FIX ATTEMPTED	WHY IT CANNOT RESOLVE THE FAILURE ALONE
Multiplier	Compresses per-creation economics into a monthly equivalent. It does not preserve the relationship.
Web checkout	Avoids Apple in some cases, but depends on legal and geographic conditions. Not a stable architecture.
Manual migration support	Human compensation for a translation the system cannot automate.
Creator communication	Moves explanation burden onto creators.
Legal action	Evidence that the product surface cannot solve the boundary problem alone.

THE KEY DISTINCTION

Interface correction improves the current frame. Redesign changes the frame.

THE VALUE LEAK — PLAIN LANGUAGE

The remittance gap in plain language: Apple may process a refund before Patreon has full settlement visibility. By then, the creator may have already delivered the work and been paid. Patreon or the creator absorbs the loss. That is the Value Leak — the gap the reconciliation reserve must structurally close. Under Path B, the exposure window is expected to shrink substantially because Patreon is the merchant of the platform subscription.

SECTION 7

THE REDESIGN FORK

The diagnosis produces two valid structural exits. They are not feature options. They are not variants of one roadmap. They are mutually exclusive strategic futures.

The Two Exits in One View:

QUESTION	PATH A — THE DECOUPLER	PATH B — THE ALLOCATION SHIFT
What Patreon becomes	Same platform, structurally upgraded	Different platform, new economic model
Core move	Preserve creator-fan patronage behind a translation layer	Replace creator-level payment with platform-level allocation
Creator-fan payment relationship	Preserved inside Patreon's system	Retired as payment relationship; preserved as allocation relationship
Apple sees	Apple-compatible subscription funding a credit ledger	One platform subscription to Patreon — no creator-level economics
Primary truth object	Credit Event Log	Patronage Allocation Ledger
What it protects	Patreon's recognisable bilateral identity	Patreon's autonomy from Apple's creator-level grammar
Legal/accounting change	Lower — entitlement accounting, App Store compliance	Higher — Patreon becomes payor of record; tax docs change
Main risk	Translation drift; Apple subscription becomes the relationship again	Category collapse; Patreon becomes a utility rather than a creator marketplace
Recommended use	The continuity-preserving path if Patreon wants to remain recognisably Patreon	A structurally valid alternative that changes what Patreon is

Path A — The Decoupler

Apple sees a subscription. Patreon treats that subscription as funding for an internal patronage ledger. Inside Patreon, the creator-fan relationship survives. A fan's money becomes credits. When the creator publishes, credits are deducted and the creator earns. Apple becomes the funding rail. Patreon remains the relationship authority.

→ Creator-defined support terms preserved

→ Per-creation logic preserved inside the Credit Event Log

→ Fan-to-creator connection preserved

→ Patreon’s original identity preserved

→ Cost: Patreon must maintain a permanent translation layer

Path B — The Allocation Shift

Apple sees one subscription to Patreon. Inside Patreon, the fan decides how their balance is allocated: £8 to one creator when they publish, £6 to another monthly. Apple never sees creator-level economics. Apple governs the platform subscription. Patreon governs the allocation of support.

→ Platform autonomy from Apple’s creator-level payment restrictions

→ Long-term insulation from Apple’s billing grammar

→ Cost: Patreon changes category. Patreon becomes the payor of record.

> CATEGORY COLLAPSE WARNING
>
> ***If Path B is badly designed, the creator no longer feels “these fans support my work.” They feel “the platform distributed money to me.” That shift is category collapse — the point where Path B stops being patronage and starts being a subscription utility.***

The hard legal difference under Path B: Patreon pays creators. Fans set allocation rules, but they are not the payor of record. That changes tax documents, accounting, reporting, and all creator-facing financial records. This is the most significant legal difference between the two paths.

SECTION 8

WHY THESE PATHS CANNOT BE COMBINED

Path A says: preserve the original relationship behind a translation layer. Path B says: replace the original payment relationship with platform allocation. Those are different primitives.

Attempting both produces the same structural condition as today: multiple payment geometries against one membership object, with no coherent primitive governing any of them. The result would not be optionality. It would be a new collapse.

> THE FINALITY CLAUSE
>
> ***The board must choose. This is not a technical choice. It is an identity decision: preserve the bilateral creator-fan model, or replace it with platform-level allocation. Once that decision is made, the architecture follows.***

SECTION 9

WHAT THE MINIMUM REDESIGN REQUIRES

The restricted Redesign Artifacts define the complete minimum replacement in full builder-grade detail. The lists below are the plain-language minimums. If any one object is missing, the redesign has not occurred — the system remains inside the old frame.

Path A — minimum replacement (plain-language):

#	REQUIRED OBJECT	PLAIN MEANING
1	Credit Event Log	Primary record of fan credits, creator publication events, debits, refunds, and reconciliation. This is the truth object. It must govern entitlement and payout.
2	Apple subscription mapping	Apple payment linked to internal credit allocation — not treated as the relationship itself.
3	Publication-triggered debit	Creator earnings follow actual publication events where per-creation terms apply.
4	Reconciliation reserve	Refund and timing risk absorbed structurally, not pushed onto creators.
5	Fan-facing credit balance interface	Fans can see credit balance and per-post debit without off-platform explanation.
6	Creator-facing per-creation earnings interface	Creators can see earnings tied to publication events and verify economic equivalence.
7	Refusal gates	Hard system rules that prevent entitlement, payout, or migration when the truth object does not support it. These cannot be bypassed by operator instruction.

Path B — minimum replacement (plain-language):

#	REQUIRED OBJECT	PLAIN MEANING
1	Patronage Allocation Ledger	Primary record of fan balances, allocation rules, allocation events, and creator payouts.
2	Platform subscription layer	Apple sees only Patreon — no creator-level economics, no creator IDs.
3	Fan allocation interface	Fans can set per-creation and monthly-fixed allocation rules per creator inside Patreon's system.
4	Allocation Rule Object	The fan's governance decision: "I allocate £X to Creator A when they publish, up to £Y/month."
5	Publication-triggered allocation	Per-creation support survives inside Patreon's allocation layer, invisible to Apple.
6	Creator payout system	Patreon becomes the governed payor of record.
7	Refusal gates	Hard system rules preventing wallet drift, payor-of-record confusion, and category collapse. The allocation interface must never present balance as generic tokens. These cannot be bypassed.

MINIMUM REPLACEMENT RULE

If these objects do not all exist, are not operational, or do not govern decisions, the redesign has not begun.

SECTION 10

WHAT MUST STOP

Preconditions, not optimisation targets. These must stop before the redesign can hold.

WHAT MUST STOP	DEADLINE	WHY
Treating the multiplier as economic translation	Immediately	It compresses the relationship. It does not preserve it.
Auto-migrating per-creation creators under the broken logic	Immediately	It installs false equivalence before the truth object exists.
Treating web checkout as the structural fix	Before redesign begins	It is contingent, partial, and legally unstable.
Treating Apple reversals as communication problems	Immediately	They are evidence of primitive incompatibility, not messaging failure.
Using creator trust as the instruction layer	Immediately	Creators should not have to teach fans how to bypass the product.
Treating Path B as a feature upgrade	Before leadership decision	It is a category transformation, not a billing improvement.
Pursuing both paths simultaneously	Before architecture work begins	It reintroduces primitive collapse inside the redesign.

SECTION 11

WHAT THE SYSTEM MUST NOW CARRY ITSELF

Eleven functions currently carried by creators, fans, and support teams. Each one must move into architecture.

CURRENT BURDEN CARRIED BY PEOPLE	MUST BECOME
Creators explaining iOS price differences	In-product price and fee explanation at the support moment
Creators telling fans to use the web	Coherent iOS support flow that does not require workaround instructions
Fans guessing what they are paying for	Clear support-state display inside Patreon
Patreon support handling per-creation migration manually	Automated transition governed by the chosen truth object
Creator communities interpreting Apple policy changes	Architecture insulated from policy reversal shock
Refund and remittance timing risk falling into confusion	Reconciliation engine and reserve model
Per-creation support compressed into monthly equivalence	Credit Event Log or Patronage Allocation Ledger preserving output-linked economics

If creators are still explaining the system after redesign, the architecture has not taken the burden.

SECTION 12

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

Sofia and Mikael's experience before and after the redesign. If these two scenarios are not meaningfully different, the redesign has not worked.

Before redesign — a concrete scenario:

Sofia publishes irregularly — sometimes four posts a month, sometimes none. She wants her fans to pay per post, up to their chosen limit. Her fan Mikael joins through iOS. Apple presents a monthly subscription. Sofia's per-creation terms are compressed into a monthly equivalent. Mikael sees a different price than on the web. Sofia has to post in her community explaining why iOS is different, telling fans to subscribe on web if they can. Patreon support may need to intervene with manual migration. The fan's intent, Sofia's output, and the payment event are no longer structurally aligned.

After Path A:

Mikael joins through iOS. Apple processes a subscription. Patreon converts that payment into credits inside the Credit Event Log. When Sofia publishes, credits are deducted. Sofia's earnings follow the publication event. Mikael can see his credit balance inside Patreon. Sofia can see earnings tied to actual posts. Apple handled payment, but Patreon preserved the relationship. Sofia doesn't need to explain anything.

After Path B:

Mikael subscribes once to Patreon. Inside Patreon, he sets an allocation rule: "Send £8 to Sofia each time she publishes." Apple does not see Sofia's name, her per-creation terms, or the allocation logic. Patreon governs Mikael's account balance, allocation events, and Sofia's payout. Sofia can see that Mikael's allocation reaches her when she publishes — the creator-fan connection remains visible as allocation, not as direct payment.

SECTION 13

WHAT PROVES THE REDESIGN IS REAL

The proof condition is behavioural, not declarative. Completion of the build proves nothing. Different response to the same pressure is the only valid proof.

PROOF CONDITION — SAME PRESSURE, DIFFERENT RESPONSE

The redesign is real when the same Apple constraint produces a different Patreon outcome. Apple announces a new billing rule. Under the current architecture, this produces months of tooling rebuilds, creator communication, and fan confusion. After Path A: Patreon updates the translation configuration. Creators do not explain the change. Fans keep seeing support-state clarity. After Path B: Apple's change does not touch creator-level economics at all. The Patronage Allocation Ledger continues operating unchanged.

Proof signals:

→ An Apple policy change no longer automatically becomes creator-facing disruption

→ Creators no longer need to tell fans to use the web

→ Fans understand what they are paying for inside the product

→ Per-creation economics are preserved by the chosen truth object

→ Refunds do not create unowned confusion between Apple, Patreon, creators, and fans

→ Manual migration support falls sharply

→ Creator communities stop carrying billing explanation as hidden labour

→ A creator who stops publishing stops receiving output-linked income automatically

If these do not happen, the redesign has not worked.

SECTION 13.1

THE PATRONAGE TRANSFER TEST

The redesign must preserve the patronage relationship as it moves through the Apple boundary.

PATH	TEST QUESTION	PASS	FAIL
Path A	Can a fan pay through iOS while Patreon still governs the real support state through credits, publication events, and creator-defined terms?	The relationship has survived translation.	Apple still defines the relationship.
Path B	Can a fan stop allocating support to Creator A without Apple ever knowing they supported Creator A?	Creator-level economics have moved out of Apple's reach.	The creator-level relationship remains exposed to Apple's grammar.

SECTION 14

FAKE PROGRESS

The redesign can appear to exist while the old failure remains. These are warning signs.

FAKE PROGRESS SIGNAL	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS
Apple subscription still defines the creator-fan relationship	Path A has failed. Apple remains the relationship authority. The Credit Event Log is not governing decisions.
Truth object exists but does not govern entitlement, allocation, or payout	The object is documentary, not operational.
Creators still explain pricing and web workarounds	Ghost structure has not dissolved. The architecture has not taken the burden.
Success measured by migration completion rather than burden removal	The redesign is being evaluated as compliance, not structural correction.
Refund handling remains unclear to creators	Reconciliation is not structurally resolved.
Path B allocation interface exists but creators feel paid by Patreon rather than supported by fans	Path B has failed its identity test. Category collapse has begun.
Path A credits exist but are hidden from fans	The truth object exists but is not legible. The fan comprehension boundary has not been met.
Path B account balance behaves like a wallet or generic fund	Category collapse is active. The financial frame has overtaken the relational frame.
Patreon says it is payor of record but product language still implies fans paid the creator	Legal/product mismatch. The payor-of-record architecture has not been implemented correctly.

Path A and Path B are blended	The primitive is unresolved. The current structural collapse is being recreated inside the redesign.

Fake progress is dangerous because it makes the redesign look complete while preserving the original break.

SECTION 15

RECAPTURE WARNING

The greatest risk after redesign is recapture: the old failure returning inside the new surface.

PATH	RECAPTURE VECTOR	DETECTION SIGNAL
Path A	Apple subscription becomes treated as the relationship again	Credit Event Log not queried for entitlement; Apple record used instead
Path A	Credit Event Log becomes secondary or symbolic	Entitlement decisions bypass the log; Apple record is primary
Path A	Multiplier logic returns as a convenience feature	Product backlog includes multiplier refinements
Path A	Fan credits become too opaque to understand	Support tickets: “Why don’t I have access — my subscription is active?”
Path A	Future team hides the Credit Event Log balance to “simplify” the interface	Fan support tickets increase; creators resume off-platform explanation. Hiding the credit balance is turning Patreon back into an Apple subscription.
Path B	Allocation becomes a vague donation pool	Fans cannot see named creator allocations; allocation interface presents generic totals
Path B	Creators lose visible connection to named supporters	Creator satisfaction survey falls below 70% “supported by specific fans”
Path B	Patreon becomes a generic subscription utility	Category collapse gate fires; fans describe experience in financial not relational terms
Path B	Patreon says payor of record but product language says fans paid the creator	Creator tax documentation or UI copy attributes income to individual fans
Path B	Balance presented as generic tokens or “Patreon Coins” rather than named creator support	Legibility Invariant violated: interface must never treat balance as generic currency. If the fan sees a number without a creator name attached, category collapse is beginning.
Both	Truth object stops governing decisions	Any entitlement or payout decision uses Apple subscription record instead of the truth object

SHARED RECAPTURE PRINCIPLE

The truth object is not a feature. It is the corrected primitive made operational. If the Credit Event Log or Patronage Allocation Ledger stops governing decisions, the redesign has failed.

SECTION 16

HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

Three reading routes. Start with the one that matches your role.

AUDIENCE	USE THIS DOCUMENT TO…	THEN GO TO…
Patreon leadership	Understand the diagnosis and choose the structural future: preserve or transform.	Diagnostic Artifact, then Redesign Executive Summary.
Product teams	Understand the difference between translation-layer redesign and allocation-model redesign.	Redesign Artifact A or B depending on chosen path.
Engineering	Identify the required truth object, system boundaries, reconciliation logic, and proof tests.	Full Redesign Artifact A or B.
Creator-facing teams	Understand what burden must leave creators and move into product architecture.	Sections 5, 10, 11, 12, and 14.
Legal and policy teams	Understand why the issue is a host-boundary failure, not merely a compliance event. Understand Path B payor-of-record implications.	Diagnostic Artifact evidence sections; Path B Section 6.2.
Creators and fans	Understand why iOS billing feels confusing and what real correction would change.	Quick Reference and Sections 1–5, 12–13.

SECTION 17

ONE-PAGE LEADERSHIP SUMMARY

The governing diagnosis, both paths, proof standard, and deferral cost · compressed to what leadership needs to make the decision.

Five questions a board member needs answered:

LEADERSHIP QUESTION	ANSWER
What is failing?	Patreon's creator-fan patronage primitive cannot be faithfully expressed inside Apple's subscription-only payment grammar.
Where does it break?	At the iOS "Join" moment, where support intent becomes an Apple-governed transaction.
Why have fixes not worked?	They operate after the Primitive Switch. They manage symptoms rather than changing the boundary logic.
What must replace it?	Either Path A (Credit Event Log preserving Patreon's bilateral model) or Path B (Patronage Allocation Ledger replacing the model with platform allocation). Choose one.
What proves it worked?	Same pressure → different response: no creator workaround burden, no manual migration dependence, no chaos from Apple changes, per-creation economics preserved by the chosen truth object.

COST OF DEFERRAL

STATUS QUO RISK: Every month without a structural exit, Patreon trains its creators that the product is broken and that they must build their own billing systems on Discord. The off-platform ghost structure grows. Creator trust in Patreon as the coherent relationship layer erodes. Delay is not a neutral holding position. It compounds.

ITEM	SUMMARY
Governing diagnosis	Patreon is being forced to translate relationship-coded patronage into Apple's transaction-coded payment grammar.
First structural break	The Primitive Switch at iOS payment initiation.
Hidden burden	Creators, fans, Patreon support, and off-platform communities carry the missing translation layer.
Corrected primitive — Path A	Apple funds. Patreon governs the relationship. Credit Event Log preserves per-creation truth.
Corrected primitive — Path B	Apple sees a platform subscription. Patreon governs internal allocation. Patronage Allocation Ledger preserves support allocation.
Continuity-preserving path	Path A, if Patreon wants to remain recognisably Patreon.
Strategic transformation path	Path B, if Patreon chooses category transformation.
What must stop	Multiplier as translation, web checkout as permanent fix, communication framing, simultaneous pursuit of both paths.
Proof of success	Creator-fan support becomes clear, output-linked economics survive, Apple changes no longer automatically become creator-facing disruption.
Recapture risk	Old payment grammar becomes the relationship again; or allocation destroys the felt directness of patronage.

SECTION 18

NEXT STEPS FOR LEADERSHIP

If the governing diagnosis is accepted, the following five steps apply in sequence.

#	ACTION	OWNER
1	Accept the governing diagnosis. The problem is not a compliance migration. The founding economic primitive cannot be expressed inside Apple's IAP grammar at the iOS boundary.	CEO and executive leadership
2	Stop the Vanish List items (Section 10). Auto-migration under multiplier, web checkout as structural fix, treating policy reversals as communication failures, pursuing both paths.	CPO and engineering lead

3	In a live engagement: sign the Diagnostic Acceptance Protocol (Diagnostic Artifact, Appendix A). 14-day deadline. Restricted redesign delivery begins only after acceptance. In this public exemplar, the protocol is reproduced in the Diagnostic Artifact.	CEO, CPO, CTO, CFO
4	Select Path A or Path B. This is a leadership identity decision, not a product or engineering decision. Both paths require leadership commitment before architecture begins.	Board and CEO
5	In a live engagement: move into the chosen restricted Redesign Artifact. In this public exemplar, both Redesign Artifacts are available. The restricted specification contains the full transition sequence, invariants, admissibility conditions, and builder handoff.	hello@jamieforrester.com

The diagnosis is not that Patreon lacks effort, communication, or billing tooling. The diagnosis is that Patreon's founding patronage model cannot be faithfully expressed inside Apple's payment grammar.

There are two real exits. Path A preserves Patreon by separating Apple's payment rail from Patreon's creator-fan relationship. Path B transforms Patreon by replacing direct creator-fan payment with platform-level funding and internal allocation.

CLOSING STATEMENT

For Patreon leadership: this document does not choose your future. It gives you the two structurally valid exits. The decision is yours. But the deadline pressure means delay is not neutral.

For evidence: use the Diagnostic Artifact.

For the redesign specifications: use Redesign Artifact A or B.

For the board-level summary: use the Redesign Executive Summary.

The choice is not between two features. It is between two futures.

WHAT THIS DEMONSTRATES

This Translation Artifact demonstrates that a structural diagnosis of this kind is explainable across audiences without weakening the governing finding. The diagnostic logic, the two replacement architectures, and the recapture resistance conditions are intact in the restricted Redesign Artifacts. This document demonstrates the method. The Diagnostic Artifact provides the evidence. The Redesign Artifacts specify the implementation. The first decision is not technical. It is identity: preserve the bilateral creator-fan model, or replace it with platform-level allocation.

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